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Hume's Account of Moral Sentimentalism

In his work *A Treatise of Human Nature* David Hume argues against the metamoral tradition of rationalism in favor of a sentimentalist framework of morality. Although Hume concedes the conception of virtue, he grounds its existence within his taxonomy as arising from sentimental impressions rather than a truth that is arrived upon through rational contemplation, resulting in his dismissal of the possibility of morality based on reason and a rejection of genuine moral obligation. I seek to establish Hume's argument through the premises that support it, and furthermore offer a possible objection in favor of moral objectivism that finds ground in the weakness of his presupposed definitions and naturalistic phenomenological foundation. First, I will define the concepts within Hume's taxonomy while summarizing the relevant structures and systems which interact within it. Then, I will reconstruct Hume's argument against a rationalist framing of morality by iterating over its premises. Finally, I will offer an objection to empiricist metamorality, followed by a possible rebuttal from the Humean school of thought.

As an empiricist, Hume builds his taxonomy from the basis of what can be experienced. Perceptions compose all of experience, with two categories for any perception to fall into: impressions or ideas. Impressions are derived from spontaneous feelings such as sensory data, the passions, and bodily awareness. They are psychological phenomena that convey reality to the

subject. Impressions presuppose ideas as the foundation of experience. Ideas, then, are based upon impressions. Ideas can be combined and configured to form novel complex ideas, but are not as forceful as the impressions which command the attention of the mind. Reason only can concern itself with ideas, as impressions are impervious to change by contemplation alone. Sentiments are a species of secondary impression which arises from the passions as an emotive categorization of a passion. (T 3.3.1) The categories that a passion may be assigned are either pleasure or pain. In the specialized case of moral sentiments, the judgement is passed as either approbation, a pleasurable category, or disapprobation, a painful category. The distinctions are simultaneously impacted by a survey of the impartial and even general view. These positive or negative reactions are the root of moral distinctions. Just as people are sensitive to different wavelengths of color and non-rationally classify them, Hume claims that by the sentiments we are sensitive to moral distinctions via the same non-rational classification. However, this argument for non-rational moral distinction only gets half of the way to understanding the impossibility of genuine moral obligation under Hume's system. The next vital portion of the taxonomy emphasizes the process to action, a definitional necessity for an obligation.

According to Hume, the process to any particular action involves a variety and combination of steps which may be unique to any other process of the same kind. Regardless of this, there are necessary relations that must be upheld in an accurate interpretation of the process. Firstly, however, it is important to define an action as willful, such that simply bodily movement, perhaps by external forces, are excluded. Furthermore, although an uninspected conception of action may associate with it the requirement of movement, inaction is also a form of action. The motivating passions which can cause intentional actions are referred to as inclinations, and every action must be preceded by an inclination. (T 3.2.6) However, inclinations can be inspired by

ideas, and thus reason. However, this does not make Hume's system vulnerable to rationalist objection because the ideas themselves cannot move a subject to action. Consider an example of spousal infidelity. Although a spouse may deduce through reason the unfaithfulness of their partner, this contemplation itself does not motivate said spouse to action. Rather, there is a non-rational motivating passion which is inspired by the reasoning and moves the spouse to confront their adulterer. Without this non-rational component, which may be a sense of morality or justice, the cuckold would just stew without taking action. Intentional actions are the immediate product of passions, in particular the direct passions, including the instincts. Thus, ideas of pleasure or pain, or even believed ideas of pleasure or pain to come, can be the causes of these motivating passions. (T 2.1.1.4, T 2.3.9.2) Inclinations are fundamental non-rational human tendencies which arise from experience, and can be plural and simultaneous in their occurrence. This allows for some inclinations to inspire action contrary to other inclinations. This dissonance is a key marker of a moral obligation. Moral obligations are dutiful actions that subjects are bound to perform despite their inclinations. The motivating passions of moral obligations are the sentiments, which incline action in favor of preferred moral distinctions. Although weighing inclinations can be contemplative, such as in disentangling moral sentiments from personal conflict, it is still sentimental in nature. With this system for action now thoroughly defined, the account of moral genesis must be explored before Hume's argument can be satisfactorily analyzed.

While moral truths can be known in Hume's system through the sentiments, this picture is still missing a key concept to achieve the totality of understanding of Hume's sentimentalism. This concept is the process of sympathy. Sympathy is the fundamental human excitation of a subject's own passions inspired by ideas in the imagination of what the other person is

experiencing due to observing impressions of that other person. The passion of sympathy is the chief source of moral distinctions. Sympathy alone, however, cannot necessitate the existence of morality. Rather, sympathy exists to allow for a societal conception of morality. This is key – in Hume's system, morality only exists to serve the public good, which in turn has a self-interested utility. This utility is derived from the beneficence of living in communities. Hume asserts a counterfactual to support this claim. He supposes a world of perfect abundance, in which the scarcity of resources is zero. Hume claims that morality is nonexistent in this world lacking competing interests because all the material needs of a person are met, and thus there is no need for cooperation or mandatory social interaction. Therefore, social norms to govern interpersonal relationships are not required. The counterfactual then holds that because the material conditions of the actual world command scarcity and therefore competition, it is in the self-interests of individuals to cooperate for their needs to be met, and thus social norms, or morality, is necessary to establish effective interrelations. Sympathy must therefore serve as the connecting phenomena from individual impressions to the public good, because the public good benefits the individual. The sentiment of morals proceeds from nothing but our sympathy with the interests of society. (T 3.3.6) Sympathy enables this alignment through the impressions of observing others. When the observed conduct themselves in a manner that invokes approval, they are deemed morally virtuous. On the other hand, when they conduct themselves in a disagreeable manner, they are deemed morally vicious. (T 3.3.1) The passions of approbation and disapprobation are qualified species of pleasure or pain, respectively. This is why Hume labels morality as non-rational; Moral statements are not labeled true or false, but rather in an emotivist manner of agreeable or disagreeable. Rationality follows from conclusions which reach a truth-value; Moral distinctions lack this. This communal morality lends itself to moral

obligations by inciting inclinations which favor upholding the social benefit, even at the expense of other self-interested inclinations. This process is called a survey of the general view, which is factored into moral considerations, all of which are not truth-evaluable, and thus non-rational.

At this point it is helpful to reiterate a summary of the process leading to a moral obligation. First, impressions observed of another person's actions give rise to the impression of a passion of approval (pleasure) or disapproval (pain) through the sympathetic mechanism. Next, these passions inform a moral distinction, which triggers an inclination to the public good. This inclination may contradict another, more selfish, inclination and motivate the observer to act. This action is a moral obligation. Between the moral inclination and action, there may be rational contemplation, but this contemplation is ultimately subservient to the final passionate motivation that invokes action. By transitivity, the direct passions of pleasure and pain are the distinguishers of virtue and vice. (T 3.1.2) Pleasure and pain are impressions, and rationality can only involve itself in ideas, therefore establishing Hume's non-rational sentimentalist position. There can be no genuine moral obligation in this account of morality. For Humean scholarship, the term 'genuine' is interchangeable with 'rational.' It can also be interpreted as acting for the sake of a moral principle, rather than out of a self-interested motivation. This is also not compatible with Hume's account, not because Hume takes a nihilistic or hedonistic stance, but rather because this definition of 'genuine' presupposes objective moral principles that can therefore be arrived upon through rational contemplation. Attributing nihilism, hedonism, or egoism to Hume's account simply because he defines pleasure as a motivator of action makes the same mistake, as each of those frameworks suppose an objective good that can be optimized for by behaving rationally. Hume furthermore does not take a relativist position by denying objective morality, but rather

Hume claims that morality stems from elements of a universal human nature, and that there are morally right and wrong ways to behave due to this common ground.

While Hume's account of morality appears sound, he smuggles in presuppositions by purely basing his line of reasoning on a psychological phenomenology. These suppositions are concerned with the functionality of underlying processes which result in psychology. Contemporary computer systems serve as a counterexample to this non-rational account by serving as a potential model for the fundamental operations from which human nature emerges. At first observation, computers may appear to behave in their own self-interested morality, functioning as their creators intend so that they are not disposed of and replaced. The interrelations between computer systems engages with a system of compatibility in distributing resources such as energy, compute, and space complexity. Computers also interact with humans by a means of expectations and norms to enable them to be of optimal service. Computers are driven by a rational process of logic in the form of binary syntactical operations underlying their behavior. This is the main comparison to human psychology, which could be driven by a similar system of rational operators underlying the human experience. Although engaging with a computer feels phenomenological because their underlying rationality is unobservable does not mean that computers are not driven by rationality. Similarly, although the human experience feels non-rational does not necessitate that underlying operators are not governed by logic. The passions which inspire morality could therefore be programmed by an inaccessible rationality, interfacing with the mind in an accessible manner the same way that software frontends are engineered to make understanding their inner-workings as intuitive and accessible as possible. The process of moral distinction would therefore be a rational process translated into phenomenology for ease of use.

This objection seems incompatible with Hume's taxonomy by introducing non-observable concepts into an empiricist framework based upon observation. However, dismissing non-observable substances is too radical of a reaction due to the impressions that non-observable substances can induce in an observer. Electrons, for example, are non-observable, yet they impact every impression of one's perception. This is where the phenomenological interpretation falls short – it cannot claim nonexistence to the things that evoke impressions. In the same vein, the inner processes of the mind cannot be dismissed simply because they are unobservable, especially because these processes are the single most affecting element of both impressions and ideas. In this case, there must be a preestablished moral framework within the governing processes of the mind which manifests itself in the Humean account, and this framework could just as well be based within a logical system.